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Governor Spanberger Announces Virginia Highlands Community College in Abingdon Receives First Rural Health Transformation Grant

The Governor Announced the \$127,000 Award & Held a Roundtable Discussion at the College to Discuss Challenges Facing Healthcare Providers in Southwest Virginia

ABINGDON, VA — Governor Abigail Spanberger today highlighted Virginia’s ongoing efforts to strengthen rural healthcare access and workforce development during a visit to Virginia Highlands Community College.

During the visit, Governor Spanberger announced a first-of-its-kind Rural Health Transformation grant: a \$127,500 award to Virginia Highlands Community College to expand healthcare workforce training opportunities. The award is funded through Virginia’s Rural Health Transformation initiative, which will deliver \$189.5 million in year-one funding as part of a multi-year effort to strengthen and modernize rural healthcare systems across the Commonwealth.

“Rural healthcare systems across Virginia are working hard to continue delivering care while facing provider shortages, workforce challenges, long travel times for patients, and growing financial pressures,” **said Governor Abigail Spanberger**. “As the so-called ‘One Big Beautiful Bill’ threatens rural healthcare providers and Virginians’ access to care, I will continue bringing providers, patients, and local leaders to the table as we chart our path forward. Amid the uncertainty out of Washington, we are working together to build stronger local systems and a more connected healthcare network.”

As part of today’s announcement, Governor Spanberger convened a roundtable discussion with local healthcare providers to hear directly about the challenges facing rural healthcare communities, including workforce shortages, access to care, and financial pressures impacting providers across Southwest Virginia.

“For too long, rural communities have been told that where you live determines the care you can access and the future you can build,” **said Secretary of Health and Human Resources Marvin Figueroa**. “This investment is about changing that. Training providers locally, building innovations that last, and connecting healthcare to economic opportunity is how rural Virginia gets stronger, healthier, and better positioned for the future.”

The Rural Health Transformation investment will support Virginia Highland Community College’s expansion of the Licensed Practical Nursing (LPN) program through additional course offerings, increased student capacity, and instructional support designed to help address critical healthcare workforce shortages across Southwest Virginia. The funding is part of the Commonwealth’s broader Homegrown Health Heroes initiative focused on strengthening rural healthcare workforce pipelines through partnerships with public education, community colleges, and local healthcare providers.

“We know that one of the best ways to strengthen rural healthcare is to train providers locally and help them build careers in the communities they call home,” **said Dr. Adam Hutchison, President at Virginia Highlands Community College.** “This investment will allow us to expand opportunities for students pursuing healthcare careers and help address critical workforce shortages across Southwest Virginia.”

The Commonwealth will continue engaging local governments, healthcare systems, educational institutions, nonprofits, and private-sector innovators as Rural Health Transformation implementation moves forward over the coming months.

“Rural Virginia is essential to the strength, economy, and future of our Commonwealth,” **said Heidi Hertz, Director of Rural Health Transformation.** “We will know this effort is succeeding when we are building lasting partnerships, rural Virginians can access quality care closer to home, and rural healthcare systems are stronger and more resilient for generations to come.”

Virginia residents, healthcare providers, educators, community organizations, and potential partners are encouraged to register for the Commonwealth’s Rural Health Transformation Webinar on June 3 to learn more about funding opportunities, implementation priorities, and ways to participate in the initiative.

For more information and to register, [click here](#).

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